MODULE 1: Introduction to Information Disorder

Objective
This section aims to build a clear, foundational understanding of information disorder among participants: what it means, why it deserves attention, and how it shapes the lives of individuals, the fabric of society, and the health of democratic institutions.

1.1 Information Disorder
Information disorder refers to a situation in which information—whether true or false—is shared inaccurately, misleadingly, or with harmful intent, influencing people's decisions, behavior, or beliefs.

In today's digital age, we encounter vast amounts of information every day through Facebook and Instagram posts, YouTube videos, WhatsApp forwards, online news, blogs, reels, and other sources. Not all information within this constant flow is accurate, relevant, or reliable.

Information disorder can take several forms:
- False information is shared unintentionally.
- Information is deliberately created to mislead.
- True information is used in ways that cause harm.

Together, these forms constitute information disorder.

In simple terms:
Information disorder occurs when information misleads people or causes harm rather than helping them understand—whether intentionally or unintentionally.

1.2 Why Does Information Disorder Matter?
Information disorder is more than an "online problem." It directly affects people's decisions and behavior in everyday life.

Effects on Individuals
- False information can lead people to make poor decisions.
- It can create unnecessary fear, anxiety, or confusion.
- It can undermine trust in personal relationships.

Effects on Society
- Rumors and misconceptions can spread across communities.
- Hostility and divisions between people can deepen.
- Social harmony and tolerance can be weakened.

Effects on Democratic and Civic Life
- Voters' decisions can be influenced.
- Political instability can increase, and social tensions can intensify.
- Trust in elections and civic processes can decline.
- Responsible civic engagement can be weakened.

For these reasons, information disorder should be understood as both a civic and a social challenge, alongside its technological dimensions.

1.3 The Bangladesh Context: Why It Matters Even More
Internet and social media use is growing rapidly in Bangladesh, with young people making up a substantial proportion of users.
Information disorder is particularly important in Bangladesh because:
- Social media often serves as a primary source of information.
- A strong culture of verifying information has yet to become established.
- Rumours spread quickly.
- False information about elections, civic rights, and public services can influence people's decisions.

Information disorder can have an even greater impact during election periods. As responsible citizens, it is therefore essential to verify information and act responsibly.

1.4 How Information Spreads

Understanding how information spreads helps us recognise why false information can circulate so quickly.

The Role of Digital Platforms

- Platforms such as Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, and WhatsApp enable information to reach large audiences.
- Algorithms often amplify content that evokes strong emotions.
- Likes, shares, and comments can help information go viral rapidly.

The Role of Human Behaviour

People often:

- Share content after reading only the headline.
- Accept information without questioning it when it aligns with their existing beliefs.
- Place greater trust in information shared by someone they know.

As a result, False information + strong emotions + rapid sharing = the spread of information disorder.

1.5 Main Forms of Information Disorder: An Overview

This course will focus on six forms of information disorder and related content practices:

- **Misinformation:** False information shared unintentionally.
- **Disinformation:** False information deliberately created or shared to mislead.
- **Malinformation:** Genuine information used to cause harm.
- **Cheap Fakes:** Misleading content produced through simple editing or manipulation.
- **Deepfakes:** Fabricated or manipulated audio or video created using artificial intelligence.
- **Clickbait:** The use of misleading headlines to attract clicks.

Each topic will be explored in detail in a separate module.

1.6 Information Disorder and Civic Responsibility

As informed citizens, we have a responsibility to:

- Verify information.
- Avoid sharing content impulsively in response to strong emotions.
- Refrain from spreading misleading content.
- Help others become more aware of information disorder.

Verifying information does not mean suppressing opinions; it means standing up for truth and responsible communication.

1.7 Key Takeaways

By the end of this module, participants will be able to explain:

- What information disorder is and why it matters.
- How false information spreads within society.
- Its impact in the Bangladesh context.
- The importance of verifying information and practising responsible civic behaviour.